

Impact: High Difficulty: Easy-Medium Misuse risk: A sceptical, courtroom tone turns "How so?" into a demand for proof, so the speaker hears ch

CORE FORMULA

You said the second option feels safer. How so? -> You are worried the launch will slip. How do you see that happening? -> You said the tone felt different. How did it come across? -> You think the client is not ready. How are you reading that? -> You said this matters more than speed. How does that show up in the decision?

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

When a person says something compressed, ask one warm, neutral "How so?" and then stop talking.

BEST FOR

- Vague evaluations like "that felt off" or "I am not convinced"
- Compressed preferences such as "I like A more than B"
- Disagreement that needs understanding before you respond
- Coaching, facilitation, customer discovery and team debriefs
- Sensitive moments where "why?" would sound too sharp
- Conversations where the speaker has more context than you do

PHRASE BANK

Neutral everyday · Everyday openers

- "How so?"
- "How do you mean?"
- "How did that land for you?"
- "How is it showing up?"
- "How are you seeing it?"
- "How does that show up?"
- "How are you reading it?"
- "How would that play out?"

Work and decisions · Professional prompts

- "How do you see that playing out?"
- "How did you arrive at that read?"
- "How would that affect the next step?"
- "How is that different from the current approach?"
- "How would we notice that risk early?"
- "How do you see it breaking down?"
- "How are you reading readiness?"
- "What would be a small signal that this is improving?"

Digital / asynchronous · Text and email prompts

- "Can you say how you are reading that?"
- "What makes it feel that way? How is it showing up?"
- "Could you give one example of how that happens?"
- "How would that change the decision from your view?"
- "Can you say how you are seeing the issue — is it audience fit, timing, or execution risk?"
- "How does that pain show up day to day?"
- "What is the main thing pointing you there?"

Warm personal · Support prompts

- "How has that been for you?"
- "How did you notice it?"
- "How did it shift things?"
- "How does it feel different this time?"
- "How are you making sense of it?"
- "How has that been showing up?"
- "How has that been affecting you day to day?"

Pressure and disagreement · Before you push back

- "I want to understand before I respond. How so?"
- "Can you walk me through how you are seeing it?"
- "What is the path from the issue to that concern?"
- "How would you define the risk here?"
- "What would make that outcome more likely?"
- "Before I push back, can you walk me through how you are seeing it?"
- "I want to understand your read before I respond. How are you seeing it?"

Softeners when trust is low · Repair the frame

- "I may not have the full picture — how so?"
- "Help me understand the shape of it. How is it showing up?"
- "I am not challenging it; I am trying to understand how it works."
- "That sounds important. How is it showing up?"
- "I want to understand before responding. How do you mean?"
- "No pressure to unpack everything — how is that showing up?"

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Why would you say that?

Better: How so?

Best: I want to understand your read before I respond. How are you seeing it?

2. Weak: What is the problem now?

Better: How so?

Best: What are you noticing that makes it feel risky?

3. Weak: Why do you prefer that?

Better: How does it work better?

Best: What about that option fits the situation better?

4. Weak: How is that true?

Better: How are you reading it?

Best: Before I push back, can you walk me through how you are seeing it?

DECISION TREE

If The statement is emotionally loaded

Reflect or validate first, then ask softly.

"That sounds important. How is that showing up?"

If One word is doing the main work

Pick up that exact word first, then ask how.

"You said 'fragile' — how is it fragile?"

If You need reasoning, mechanism or an example

Ask one open How-so prompt, then stop and let it breathe.

"How so?"

If They expand constructively

Reflect, summarise, or chain to the next step.

"So the issue is adoption, not interest."

If They tighten or sound defensive

Repair the frame before asking again; do not repeat the prompt.

"I am not challenging it — I am trying to understand."

If Enough is clear now

Stop asking and respond; if not, ask one narrower how-question.

"What is the main thing pointing you there?"

SCENARIOS

Team disagreement — "This timeline is unrealistic."

Ask how it breaks down; listen for dependency, capacity or stakeholder timing, then reflect the real blocker. — "How do you see it breaking down?"

Customer discovery — "The old tool is painful."

Ask how the pain shows up day to day; listen for frequency, cost and workarounds. — "How does that pain show up day to day?"

Personal support — "I just feel disconnected lately."

Soften, then ask how it has been showing up; listen for routine, mood and energy before naming it. — "How has that been showing up?"

Leadership decision — "The team is not ready."

Ask how they are reading readiness; listen for skill, confidence and alignment, then look for a small signal. — "How are you reading readiness?"

Digital message — "I am not sure this direction works."

Reply with a category-offering how-question so they can name the type of concern, then respond to the category. — "Can you say how you are seeing the issue — is it audience fit, timing, or execution risk?"

Sensitive one-to-one where "why?" would sound sharp

Cushion first, then ask how, so the question reads as care rather than challenge. — "I want to understand before I respond. How are you seeing it?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- The person is in acute distress and needs support, not elaboration
- They have already explained and you would only be repeating the prompt
- The answer is obvious and the question would feel performative
- The moment needs a direct answer, decision or boundary
- Your tone would carry scepticism, impatience or challenge
- They have signalled they do not want to go deeper
- Physical safety or an immediate emergency takes priority

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Notice the compression

Through the day, catch three vague statements — a preference, a concern and a reaction — and just note them. Do not respond yet; only practise recognising when something is compressed.

Day 2 — Turn vague into how

Take yesterday's three statements and write one neutral How-so prompt for each, under twelve words. Cut any version that really means "why" or "prove it."

Day 3 — Say it warmly

Say each prompt aloud twice — once flat, once curious. Keep only the warm version and notice how tone alone changes it from challenge to invitation.

Day 4 — Cushion for high stakes

Rewrite two prompts with a respect signal in front, e.g. "I want to understand before I respond. How are you seeing it?" Use these when tension is likely.

Day 5 — Let silence work

In one real conversation, ask a single How-so prompt and count two full breaths before adding anything. Notice what the other person fills the space with.

Day 6 — Catch the mechanism

Use the prompt once and, instead of asking again, reflect the real criterion back: "So the issue is X, not Y." Check whether they say "exactly."

Day 7 — Ask, then move

Use How-so to open, reflect what you heard, then chain into a next step — a summary, a bounded request or permission-based advice. Stop asking once enough is clear.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I ask for understanding rather than proof?
- Was the prompt short, with no stacked questions?
- Was my tone curious rather than sceptical?
- Did I give silence room to work before adding anything?
- Did I listen for the mechanism, example or criterion?
- Did I stop and reflect once enough was clear, rather than cornering them?